

Topic 3.1 - What "an effective teacher" actually means

A real classroom situation

Two teachers take Class 9 mathematics in neighbouring rooms of the same government school in Larkana. At the end of the year their board results are almost identical.

Mr Junaid's room is silent. He works through the past five years of board papers, question by question. Pupils copy his worked solutions and reproduce them. Anyone who asks a question that is not on the syllabus is told there is no time. His pupils pass.

Miss Shazia's room is noisier. She spends the first term on why the methods work, which costs her three weeks she never gets back, and she pushes pupils to attempt problems before she has shown them how. Two of her weakest pupils fail the mock badly and recover by March. Her pupils pass at the same rate as Mr Junaid's.

Which of them is the effective teacher? The honest answer is that it depends entirely on what you decided to count before you walked in, and this topic is about taking that decision seriously rather than pretending it has already been made for you.

Explanation

Redefining effective teaching and the effective teacher

Teacher effectiveness is usually defined as the effect a teacher has on what their pupils learn. That sentence sounds settled and is not, because everything

depends on which effects you count and how you detect them.

Goe, Bell and Little (2008) report that there is no generally agreed method for evaluating teacher effectiveness. Grouping what they and others describe, the definitions in use fall into three recognisable families. The grouping below is this book's, offered as a way to hold the field in mind rather than as their taxonomy:

Effectiveness as achievement gain. The teacher's effect is the improvement in pupils' measured attainment over a year, ideally compared against what similar pupils elsewhere achieved. It has the great merit of being about learning rather than about the teacher's manner. Its weakness is that it counts only what the test tests. Mr Junaid does extremely well on this definition.

Effectiveness as observed practice. The teacher's effect is inferred from what they are seen to do: how they explain, question, respond, manage time. It captures things a test cannot, and it is what most classroom observation instruments measure. Its weakness is that it can reward a performance. A lesson can look excellent and teach nobody anything, and observers are not immune to being impressed.

Effectiveness as breadth of learner outcomes. The teacher's effect includes attainment but also what else changed: whether pupils became more willing to attempt hard problems, whether attendance held, whether a pupil who intended to leave stayed. Miss Shazia looks strongest here. Its weakness is that these outcomes are genuinely hard to measure, and what is hard to measure is easy to assert.

Taylor and Thion (2023) put a sharper point, though note what they studied: reviewing the research literature on teaching effectiveness, they found many papers using inaccurate or merely implied definitions, so that the definition stated and the thing actually measured came apart. Their subject is research, not school appraisal. The same gap is easy to recognise in a school, where an institution may say it values deep understanding and appraise its teachers on examination results, and the appraisal is what teachers respond to. That extension is a reasonable inference rather than their finding.

So what should a trainee conclude? Not that effectiveness is meaningless. The three families agree on more than they disagree about. What follows is narrower and more useful: whenever someone calls a teacher effective, ask

what was counted. And when you are evaluated, find out which definition is in force before you plan your year around the wrong one.

This dismantles a misconception worth naming: *an effective teacher is one whose class gets high marks*. That is one definition, not the definition, and it is the one most vulnerable to being achieved in ways nobody wants. A teacher can raise marks by narrowing teaching to the test, which raises the measure and lowers the learning it was supposed to indicate.

The components of teacher effectiveness, and what each can and cannot show

Rather than one definition, it is more workable to hold a set of components, each of which can be observed and none of which is sufficient alone. The figure above groups them in the way the research literature tends to: what happens inside the room, and what happens outside it.

Within-classroom processes

- *Subject and pedagogical knowledge*. Knowing the content, and knowing how that particular content is learned and misunderstood. The second is not implied by the first, which is why a brilliant mathematician can teach mathematics badly.
- *Planning and structure*. Whether a lesson has a destination, and whether the parts serve it.
- *Explanation and questioning*. Whether ideas are made available, and whether questions discover what pupils think or merely check that someone can say the right words.
- *Use of assessment*. Whether the teacher finds out what pupils have understood and then does something different because of it. A teacher who tests frequently and teaches identically afterwards is not using assessment.
- *Classroom climate and management*. Whether the room is a place where a pupil can risk being wrong. Unit 2's account of trust is this component seen from the ethical side.

Beyond the classroom

- *Contribution to colleagues.* Whether the teacher's practice improves anyone else's.
- *Relationships with parents and community.* Covered in Topic 3.3.
- *Professional learning.* Whether the teacher is still changing. Covered in Topic 3.5.

Two cautions about using components at all.

First, **components are evidence, not a score**. Adding them up produces a number that feels objective and hides every judgement that went into it. Goe and colleagues are explicit that different components are appropriate for different purposes, and that an instrument built for professional development should not be reused for high-stakes appraisal.

Second, **the components interact**. Strong subject knowledge with a hostile climate produces less learning than moderate subject knowledge with a safe one, because pupils in the second room will admit what they do not understand. Reading the list as independent boxes to tick misses the thing that actually makes a classroom work.

Return to Mr Junaid and Miss Shazia with the components in hand and the picture sharpens. Mr Junaid is strong on structure and weak on questioning and assessment use, because nothing he does discovers what pupils think. Miss Shazia is strong on climate, questioning and assessment use, and paid three weeks for it. Neither is simply better. But only one of them could tell you what their pupils misunderstand, and that is the difference that compounds over a career.

Activity: What did you count?

Work in groups of three. Each group takes one of the three definitions from the figure at the top of this topic: achievement gain, observed practice, or breadth of learner outcomes.

From your definition alone, write the appraisal you would give Mr Junaid and the appraisal you would give Miss Shazia. Be specific: state what evidence you would collect and what verdict it supports.

Then hear all three groups in turn. Two questions for the class afterwards. Which teacher's appraisal changed most between definitions, and why? And which definition would you want applied to you in your first year of teaching, given what you would be able to demonstrate?

Allow 25 minutes.

Check your understanding

1. State three competing definitions of teacher effectiveness and, for each, one thing it captures well. (*Remember*)
2. Explain why a teacher can be judged effective on one definition and ineffective on another using the same evidence. (*Understand*)
3. Distinguish within-classroom processes from factors beyond the classroom, giving two examples of each. (*Remember*)
4. A teacher tests their class every fortnight and teaches the next unit identically regardless of the results. Which component are they failing, and why does frequent testing not rescue it? (*Apply*)
5. Explain why adding the components into a single score is a worse instrument than holding them separately. (*Analyze*)

Summary

Teacher effectiveness means the effect a teacher has on pupils' learning, but the definitions in use disagree about which effects count. Achievement gain counts what the test tests; observed practice counts what an observer can see and can be satisfied by performance; breadth of learner outcomes counts more of what matters and measures it less reliably. Institutions frequently state one definition and appraise against another.

More workable than a definition is a set of components: subject and pedagogical knowledge, planning, explanation and questioning, use of assessment, and classroom climate within the room; contribution to colleagues, relationships beyond it, and continued professional learning outside. The components are evidence rather than a score, they are chosen for a purpose, and they interact, so a strong component can be cancelled by a weak one.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can state three competing definitions of teacher effectiveness and what each misses.
- ☐ I can explain why the definition an institution states and the measure it uses often differ.
- ☐ I can name the components of teacher effectiveness and sort them into within-classroom and beyond-classroom.
- ☐ I can judge a described teacher against the components rather than by overall impression.
- ☐ I can explain why using assessment means changing what you do next, not testing more often.

Try this at your practicum school

Find out how teachers in your practicum school are actually appraised. Ask your mentor what is looked at, who looks at it, and how often.

Then compare what you are told against the three definitions in this topic. Write half a page identifying which definition the school's appraisal is closest to, what that definition rewards, and one thing a teacher in that school could do to score well without teaching better. That last part is not cynicism; it is the standard test of whether a measure is robust.

Summative task

Write 400 to 450 words.

Mr Junaid and Miss Shazia produced the same board results. Judge them both against the components of teacher effectiveness and reach a defensible verdict.

Your answer must use at least four named components, cite specific evidence from the vignette rather than impressions, state clearly what evidence you do

not have and would need, and reach a verdict rather than concluding that both have strengths.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Use of components (Apply)	Names at least four components and applies each to both teachers, not just the convenient ones
Evidence discipline	Distinguishes what the vignette states from what the writer is inferring
Reasoned verdict (Evaluate)	Reaches a verdict and defends the criterion it rests on, rather than retreating to "both have strengths"
Recognition of limits	States what further evidence would change the verdict and why

Further reading

- Goe, L., Bell, C., & Little, O. (2008). *Approaches to evaluating teacher effectiveness: A research synthesis*. National Comprehensive Center for Teacher Quality. <https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED521228.pdf>
- Taylor, S., & Thion, S. (2023). How has teaching effectiveness been conceptualized? Questioning the consistency between definition and measure. *Frontiers in Education*, 8. <https://doi.org/10.3389/feduc.2023.1253622>

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